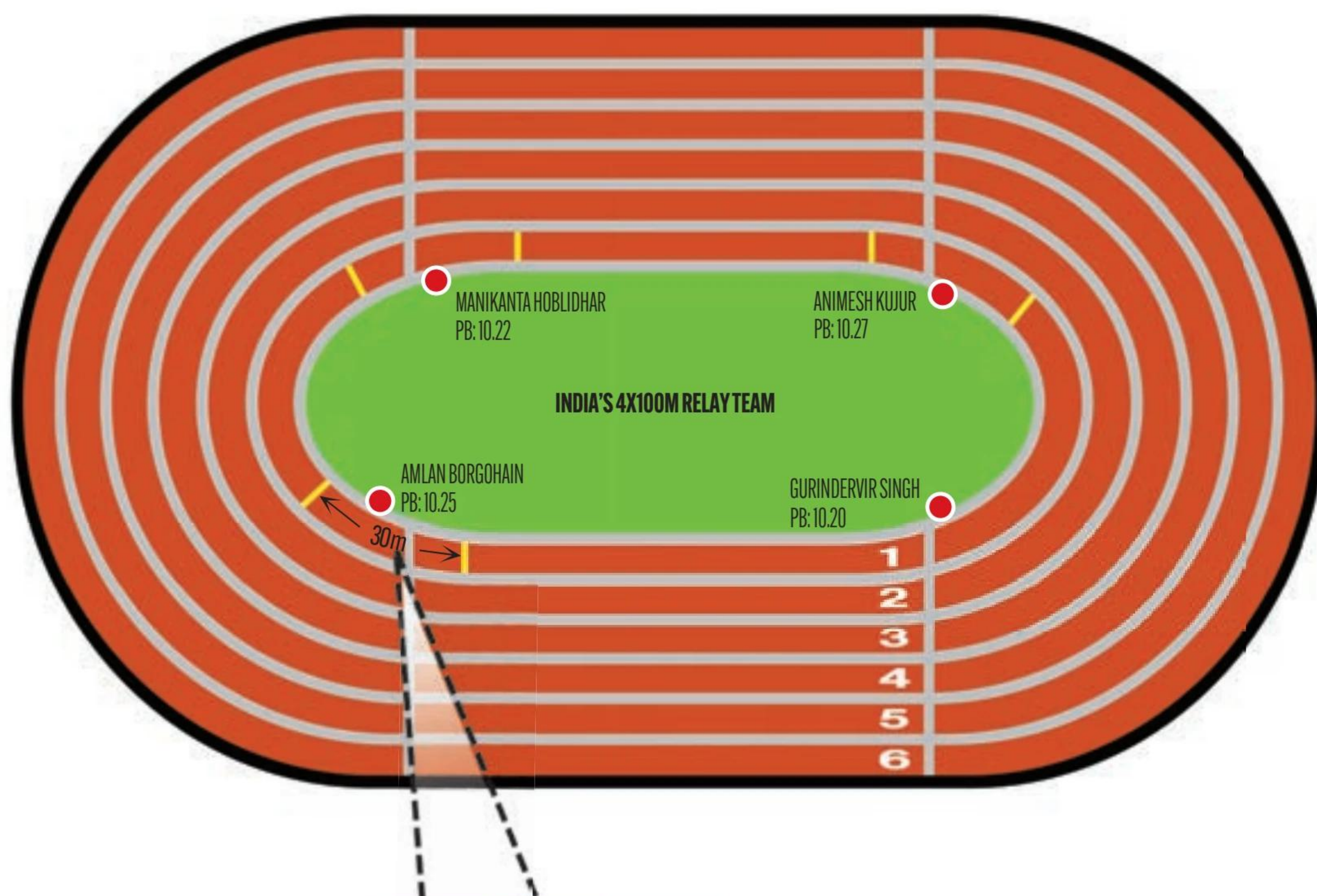


Hillier explains the running order

The first leg is Gurindervir because you need a good starter and finisher. It is also the longest carry because you're carrying the baton for 120m. The second leg is one of your longer legs. So, you want a 200m athlete. That's where Animesh is a good option. Third leg, you want a shorter athlete because you have to go around the bend, and Manikanta is apt. He can go low 10.6 around the bend and has great chemistry with Animesh. In the final leg, you need a chaser. Amlan is perfect for it. He's a very good finisher, and he's good with a rolling start.



According to Hillier, the Indian sprint relay team has been going for safer exchanges so far. He expects the team to start making their changeovers towards the end of the box. With perfect exchanges, he expects the team to get close to 38.00, or even go below the mark.



Exchanging in the final third

Why risky?

By pushing into the final third, where both runners are at a higher acceleration, there is a greater probability of a baton drop or an exchange zone infringement.

Why faster?

By exchanging in the final third, the baton passes through the box faster, with both incoming and outgoing runners accelerating for a longer duration.

the World Athletics Relays in Guangzhou, which offered 14 of the 16 direct qualification spots for the Worlds. Jamaica, which missed out on qualifying in Guangzhou, is likely to claim one of the two remaining slots through the top season-best list. For India to claim the last spot, it

must at least better the Netherlands' season-best of 38.20 seconds.

For Hillier, even this ambitious goal feels within reach — because of the progress already made.

"It's been a real challenge to get here — to convince people that Indian sprinters are good enough,

that they can compete, and even win medals — not just in Asia but potentially at the world level.

"We've had to swim against the tide, against the idea that India doesn't have the athletes for a sprint relay. That mindset is changing. And that's crucial."